

PLAN B · BANDUNG IS OFF (ANAK KRAKATAU)

Vietnam — Hanoi & Sapa

7 - 12 September 2026

Haris Haikal & Aina Izzaty · same six days, same outfit themes, no driver needed
Sapa's rice terraces are gold and being harvested in exactly this window.

The Six Days

DAY	DATE	SHAPE	WHERE	SLEEP
Day 1	Mon, 7 Sep	Fly + transfer	KUL → Hanoi → Sapa	Sapa
Day 2	Tue, 8 Sep	Golden terraces	Cat Cat, Muong Hoa valley	Sapa
Day 3	Wed, 9 Sep	Mountain + cafés	Fansipan, Sapa town	Sapa
Day 4	Thu, 10 Sep	Transfer + city	Sapa → Hanoi Old Quarter	Move → Hanoi
Day 5	Fri, 11 Sep	Full day Hanoi	Temples, cafés, souvenirs	Hanoi
Day 6	Sat, 12 Sep	Fly home	Hanoi → KUL	—

Book Tonight, In This Order

1 Ask Malaysia Airlines to reroute, don't cancel

MAS flies KUL–Hanoi themselves. If they cancel the CGK flight, ask to be moved onto their Hanoi service instead of taking the refund — cheapest way to switch.
+60 3-7843-3000

2 Flights KUL → HAN, 7 Sept

~4+ departures a day, earliest 06.05 (AirAsia); also Vietnam Airlines, Vietjet, Batik. 3h 25m. Book the 12 Sept return at the same time.

3 Noi Bai → Sapa transfer, 7 Sept

Limousine van direct from the airport, ~5.5–6.5 hours, meets you in arrivals. Book before you fly.

4 Sapa → Hanoi transfer, 10 Sept morning

Same operators, book both legs together if you can.

5 Hotels: 3 nights Sapa (7–9), 2 nights Hanoi Old Quarter (10–11)

Sapa: valley-view room is worth it. Hanoi: stay inside Hoan Kiem so you can walk.

6 Cancel or move the Bandung side

Holiday Inn Pasteur, Swiss-Belresort Dago, Fairfield CGK — ask for a waiver citing the airport closure. Message Kiki.

7 Travel insurance

Re-issue for Vietnam, and keep the Bandung cancellation paperwork for the claim.

8 eSIM for Vietnam + download offline maps

Sapa and the valley have patchy signal, same as the highlands.

Good To Know

Visa

Malaysians: visa-free, 30 days. Carry proof of onward travel and hotel bookings.

Getting around

Grab and Xanh SM (electric taxis) everywhere in Hanoi. In Sapa: hotel cars, xe om, or a hired car for the valley. No driver to arrange.

Time

Vietnam is UTC+7 — one hour behind Malaysia, same as Jakarta was.

Money

Vietnamese dong (VND). Cards work in cities; Sapa markets and villages are cash.

Weather

Sapa 18–25°C, cool nights, passing showers. Hanoi warm and humid, 28–32°C. Pack a rain shell and one warm layer.

Why now

Sapa's terraces are gold and being harvested in the first half of September — your exact dates.

Flight out: _____ Flight home: _____ Booking ref: _____
Sapa van (out): _____ Sapa van (back): _____
Flight times and frequencies checked 6 Sept 2026 — confirm live availability and fares when booking.

DAY 1

Fly to Hanoi → straight up to Sapa

Monday, 7 September

START

Very early KLIA

FINISH

~16.00 in Sapa

SLEEP

Sapa (nights 1-3)

Outfit: Comfy travel outfit — layers, Sapa is cool on arrival

TIME	WHERE	HOW LONG	NOTES
06.05	KUL → HAN — earliest departure KLIA (check which terminal your airline uses)	3h 25m	AirAsia has the 06.05; Malaysia Airlines, Vietjet, Vietnam Airlines and Batik also fly this route — about 4+ departures a day, so there is room to move. Vietnam is 1 hour behind Malaysia .
~08.30	Land at Noi Bai (HAN), Terminal 2 Hanoi	~1h	Immigration is visa-free for Malaysians (30 days). Grab a SIM/eSIM and VND cash at the airport, and eat before the transfer.
TRANSFER: Noi Bai → Sapa by limousine van — ~5.5-6.5 hours, book in advance			
~15.30	Check in — Sapa town Sapa, Lao Cai province	1h	Vans pick up in the arrivals hall and drive straight up, no need to go into Hanoi first. Rest stop halfway.
~17.00	Sapa Stone Church + Sapa Lake Sapa town centre Open in Google Maps	1h	Easy first evening on foot. The church square is the town's meeting point.
~18.30	Dinner in town + Sapa night market Sapa town centre	2h	Grilled skewers, hotpot, salmon (Sapa farms it). Cool evening — bring the jacket out.

NOTES FOR THE DAY

- Long travel day by design, exactly like the old Day 1 — a flight then a long road transfer.
- Book the Noi Bai→Sapa van **before you fly**; the good ones sell out and you do not want to negotiate at 08.30 with luggage.
- Sapa sits at ~1,500 m. Nights are 15-18°C. The warm layer you packed for Kawah Putih is exactly right.

DAY 2

Golden rice terraces — Muong Hoa valley

Tuesday, 8 September

START
08.30

FINISH
~20.00

SLEEP
Sapa (night 2)

Outfit: Emerald denim casual — green denim against gold terraces

TIME	WHERE	HOW LONG	NOTES
08.30	Breakfast, then out	—	Ask the hotel about the day's weather. Mornings are the clear window in September.
~09.00	Cat Cat Village 2 km from Sapa town Open in Google Maps	2.5h	Terraces, waterfall, H'Mong village, and the swing/photo spots. Walk down, take a xe om or car back up — it is steep.
~20 min by car			
~12.00	Lunch in town Sapa town centre	1h	
~13.30	Muong Hoa Valley — Lao Chai & Ta Van Muong Hoa valley, below Sapa town Open in Google Maps	3.5h	The reason to be here this week. The terraces are gold and being harvested in the first half of September, with buffaloes and farmers still working them. Hire a car or a local guide for the loop; easy walking sections between viewpoints.
~30 min back up to town			
~18.00	Sunset café over the valley Sapa town, valley-facing	1.5h	Viettrekking, The Haven, or any terrace café on the ridge. Golden hour over the terraces is the shot of the trip.
~19.30	Dinner — Sapa local Sapa town centre	1.5h	

NOTES FOR THE DAY

- September light is soft and warm early and late — plan the terrace photos for before 10.00 and after 16.00.
- Take a light rain shell. Showers pass through and then it clears.
- Shoes with grip: the terrace paths are clay and slippery after rain.

DAY 3

Fansipan summit + Sapa cafés

Wednesday, 9 September

START
09.00

FINISH
~20.00

SLEEP
Sapa (night 3)

Outfit: Cream elegant — the pagodas and cloud decks suit it

TIME	WHERE	HOW LONG	NOTES
09.00	Sun World Fansipan Legend — cable car Station is ~10 min from Sapa town Open in Google Maps	4h	Record-holding cable car to Indochina's highest peak (3,143 m). Pagoda complex, gardens and cloud sea at the top. It is cold and windy up there — cream outfit plus the warm layer.
~15 min back to town			
~13.30	Lunch in town Sapa town centre	1h	
~15.00	Sapa café afternoon Sapa town centre Open in Google Maps	2.5h	Cong Caphe for coconut coffee, then a valley-view terrace. This is the Braga-and-Congo part of the old plan, transplanted.
~18.00	Sapa market — souvenirs Sapa town centre Open in Google Maps	1h	Brocade, indigo textiles, and the H'Mong embroidery. Bargaining expected, politely.
~19.30	Dinner + pack	1.5h	Long road day tomorrow — bags ready tonight.

NOTES FOR THE DAY

- If the summit is fogged in, flip this day with Day 2 — the cable car is worth a clear morning.
- Buy the cable car ticket at the station or online; it includes the funicular from the station up to the cable car.

DAY 4

Back to Hanoi — Old Quarter evening

Thursday, 10 September

START 08.00 from Sapa	FINISH ~21.30	SLEEP Hanoi Old Quarter (nights 4-5)
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Outfit: Cute pink & white — Hanoi's yellow colonial walls are the backdrop

TIME	WHERE	HOW LONG	NOTES
08.00	Checkout, board the van back Sapa town	—	Morning departures are the most comfortable. Confirm the seat the night before.
TRANSFER: Sapa → Hanoi — ~5.5-6 hours down the expressway			
~14.00	Check in — Hanoi Old Quarter Hoan Kiem district	1h	Stay inside the Old Quarter or the French Quarter and you can walk most of the next two days.
~15.30	Hoan Kiem Lake + Ngoc Son Temple Hoan Kiem Open in Google Maps	1.5h	The red bridge is the classic Hanoi photo. Five minutes from the Old Quarter.
10 min walk			
~17.00	Egg coffee — Cafe Giang or Note Coffee Old Quarter Open in Google Maps	1h	Cà phê trứng, the Hanoi original. Note Coffee is the wall-of-sticky-notes one.
~18.30	St Joseph's Cathedral + Nha Tho street Hoan Kiem Open in Google Maps	1h	Neo-gothic cathedral, café street either side, best light just before dark.
~20.00	Dinner + Ta Hien street Old Quarter	1.5h	Bun cha, pho, banh mi. Ta Hien is the busy corner street — lively, safe, loud.

NOTES FOR THE DAY

- Hanoi in September is warm and humid, ~28-32°C — the opposite of Sapa. Pack the layers away.
- Weekend evenings the Old Quarter goes car-free, but you arrive Thursday, so expect normal traffic.
- Crossing the road: walk slowly and steadily, do not stop. The scooters flow around you.

DAY 5

Hanoi full day — temples, cafés, souvenirs

Friday, 11 September

START
08.30

FINISH
~21.00

SLEEP
Hanoi Old Quarter (night 5)

Outfit: Elegant modern — cream and refined, same as the old Day 3

TIME	WHERE	HOW LONG	NOTES
08.30	Breakfast — pho at a street shop Old Quarter	45 min	Pho bo or pho ga, plastic stools, best breakfast of the trip.
~09.30	Temple of Literature Dong Da, ~10 min by Grab Open in Google Maps	1.5h	Vietnam's first university, 1070. Courtyards, red gates, calligraphy — the elegant-outfit location of the day.
~15 min by Grab			
~11.30	Tran Quoc Pagoda + West Lake Tay Ho Open in Google Maps	1.5h	Oldest pagoda in Hanoi, on a causeway in the lake. Lunch at a West Lake café after.
~15 min by Grab			
~14.30	Hanoi Train Street (from a café) Tran Phu / Phung Hung area Open in Google Maps	1h	The track is barricaded — you go in as a café customer. Check the day's train times with the café; they know.
~16.00	Souvenirs — Hang Gai silk street Old Quarter	1.5h	Silk, lacquerware, ceramics, and Vietnamese coffee beans. This is the Kartika Sari slot of the old plan.
~18.00	Sunset — Long Bien Bridge or a rooftop Old Quarter edge Open in Google Maps	1h	
~19.30	Farewell dinner French Quarter or Old Quarter Open in Google Maps	1.5h	Cha ca la vong (turmeric fish) is the Hanoi speciality worth planning around.

NOTES FOR THE DAY

- Everything today is 10–15 minutes apart by Grab or Xanh SM. No driver needed.
- If it rains hard, swap Train Street for the Ceramic Mosaic wall or a coffee crawl — Hanoi is a good rain city.
- Pack tonight and keep the coffee/silk in carry-on if it's fragile.

DAY 6

Fly home

Saturday, 12 September

START

Depends on flight

FINISH

KUL

SLEEP

—

Outfit: Comfy travel outfit

TIME	WHERE	HOW LONG	NOTES
08.00	Breakfast + last walk Old Quarter	1.5h	Hoan Kiem Lake in the morning is full of people exercising — a nice last hour.
~10.30	Checkout → Noi Bai Airport (HAN) ~45 min by Grab or hotel car	—	International departures are Terminal 2. Allow for traffic on the bridge.
~11.30	Check-in + immigration Noi Bai Terminal 2	2h buffer	Standard 2 hours for an international departure.
afternoon	HAN → KUL	~3h 25m	Vietnam is 1 hour behind, so you land in Malaysia later on the clock than the flight time suggests.

NOTES FOR THE DAY

- Book the return on whichever airline you flew out with if you want one booking reference for the whole trip.